

Moral vacuum

As part of the postwar Allied occupation of Austria, Vienna had been divided into four zones—US, British, French, and Soviet—with a jointly controlled central district. *The Third Man* exploits the political tensions that existed between the occupying forces, and the dramatic potential of characters' movements between the sectors. Those without papers, such as Anna, are desperate to avoid the Soviet sector, where their fate is uncertain.

As far as Lime is concerned, this situation has created the perfect moral vacuum, in which inventive, dynamic, ruthless men such as him can, and should, thrive. Europe is world-weary and cynical in the aftermath of the war, and for Lime, his fellow American, Martins, is a naive child stepping into it.

Improvised lines

Greene's script for *The Third Man* is as taut as you would expect from such a peerless writer, but some of the movie's most memorable lines were improvised by Welles. One reason for the movie's durability is that it successfully connects the talents of three hugely gifted men: Reed, Greene, and Welles.

Lime looks down from the wheel on the people like dots below, and asks Martins if he would feel pity if one of them "stopped moving forever". He challenges Martins: "If I offered you twenty thousand pounds for every dot that stopped,

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Over it all spreads the melancholy, inert beauty of a ruined city, passive on the surface, twitching with uneasy life underneath.

Vogue, 1949

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would you really, tell me to keep my money, or would you calculate how many dots you could afford to spare?"

Back on the ground, Lime says, in lines added in by Welles for timing: "You know what the fellow said—in Italy, for 30 years under the Borgias, they had warfare, terror, murder and bloodshed, but they produced Michelangelo, Leonardo da Vinci, and the Renaissance. In Switzerland, they had brotherly love, they had 500 years of democracy and peace, and what did that produce? The cuckoo clock." According to Welles, the words came from an old Hungarian play. Ironically, the Swiss did not invent the cuckoo clock at all, and they had been decidedly warlike at the time of the Borgias. Nonetheless, the words seem to sum up perfectly Lime's amoral outlook on the world. ■

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Harry Lime / *The Third Man*



Carol Reed Director

Born in London in 1906, Carol Reed was the son of the famous Shakespearean actor-producer Herbert Beerbohm Tree and his mistress May Reed, whose name he took. He started acting at an early age, and joined the theater company of the thriller writer Edgar Wallace, becoming his personal assistant. This led to his first work as an assistant director.

Reed's early movies as a director, such as *Midshipman Easy* (1935), met with only moderate success, but the novelist Graham Greene saw great potential in them. Reed made his first significant movie, *Odd Man Out*, about an Irish terrorist on the run, in 1947. The producer, Alexander Korda, introduced Reed to Greene and they made two great movies together, *The Fallen Idol* and *The Third Man*, which was critically acclaimed and a huge box-office success. Reed died in London in 1976.

Key movies

1947 *Odd Man Out*
1948 *The Fallen Idol*
1949 *The Third Man*
1968 *Oliver!*